ECON 5540/6540-090: COMPARATIVE SYSTEMS

Fall 2026 (Online)

Instructor: Ayixunbati Nuerlantai (Eisen)
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Office Hours: Monday 2:30-4:00 PM by appointment

Required Materials:

1) Rosser Jr, J. Barkley, and Marina V. Rosser. Comparative economics in a transforming world economy. Mit Press, 2018.
2) Gregory, Paul R., and Robert C. Stuart. The global economy and its economic systems. (2014).

Course Description:

Comparative economic systems as a sub-discipline of economics used to focus primarily on the differences between the dominant paradigms of capitalism and socialism. Since most of the socialist economies disintegrated 30 years ago, the sub-discipline has shifted its focus towards the broad examination of institutions within different variations of the dominant global economic system, capitalism.

The purpose of this course is to examine and understand the logic and historical evolution of capitalism and socialism as economic systems. In the second part of this course, we will examine different national varieties of capitalist economies, especially concentrating on the USA, China, Russia, and India. We are going to look at specific country examples, the challenges they have faced (or are currently facing), and how they have evolved or transitioned into a different economic system. Throughout the course, we will also be learning about data cleaning and analysis of economic and political databases, especially focusing on the issue of rising inequality. There are two databases that we will be using:

1) Comparative Political Dataset
2) Piketty-Saez Inequality Database

Course Outcomes & Objectives:

By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Define capitalism and socialism and identify the major variants of each economic system.
- Improve your critical thinking skills by understanding and evaluating the majorarguments for and against each variant.
- Analyze cross-country data using simple graphs.
- Sharpen your writing skills.
- Sharpen Data Interpretation skills

Important Dates:

Classes Begin	Monday, August 24
Last Day to Add, Drop (Delete), or Audit Classes	Friday, September 4
Labor Day	Monday, September 7
Fall Break	October 10–18
Last Day to Withdraw from Classes and Elect CR/NC	Friday, November 13
Thanksgiving Break	November 26–29
Last Day to Reverse CR/NC Option	Friday, December 4
Classes End	Thursday, December 10
Final Exam Period	December 14–18

Teaching and Learning Methods:

This class is completely based on recorded online videos and there is no in-person component. This course emphasizes critical thinking skills by presenting the field of comparative economic systems as a series of debates. I encourage you to identify the different schools of thought in each debate and evaluate their different arguments based on your independent reading of the evidence.

Canvas Time Zone Information:

To ensure you are viewing due dates and times correctly, as well as events in the calendar, set your student Canvas time zone to your current location by following this guide https://community.canvaslms.com/t5/Canvas-Basics-Guide/How-do-I-set-a-time-zone-in-my-user-account/ta-p/615318 If you do not change your time zone, all due dates and times listed in Canvas default to Mountain Time. Content written by instructors, such as office hours written in the syllabus, are in Mountain Time, unless stated otherwise.

Netiquette:

Students are expected to follow the core rules of netiquette (http://www.albion.com/netiquette/corerules.html) at all times while participating in the class, interacting with other students, and communicating with the course instructor.

Course Policies:

There are no particular attendance requirements. Students are expected to go through all the online videos to prepare for the quizzes, reaction papers and essays in the class. You are expected to also meet the necessary deadlines for the class. There will be opportunities for extra credit.

1. Late Assignments and Exams

The due dates on quizzes, exams, discussion threads, and all other assignments are intended to help you stay on track in the course and identify questions about the core concepts before the class moves on. Please note due dates and work each week to keep up with the course. **Late exams will not be accepted without an excuse from the University or a medical professional.**

2. Final Grade Policy

Final grades are calculated based strictly on the weighted average of all assignments, as listed in the syllabus. Grades will not be rounded or adjusted unless there is a documented error in calculation. Please do not email asking for extra credit, makeup work, or grade bumps at the end of the term. All opportunities to earn points are built into the course structure.

Syllabus Changes:

This syllabus is meant to serve as an outline and guide for our course. Please note that I may modify it with reasonable notice to you. I may also modify the Course Schedule to accommodate the needs of our class. Any changes will be posted to Canvas under Announcements.

Assignments:

Each assignment will be weighted, with a larger focus on Midterm and the Final exam.

1) Quizzes (20%): There will be 5 quizzes in total, each worth 10 points. The quiz with the lowest score will be dropped.

2) Midterm (35%)- The midterm exam will be worth 40 points. The midterm exam will be one reaction paper from a list of papers that will be shared on Canvas. The reaction paper is to be at most 5 pages long, double spaced with 3 broad components: A short Summary, Reader's reaction to the paper and Suggestions for further improvements in the paper.

3) Final exam(35%)- The final exam will be worth 50 points and will be in the form of a term paper on a topic chosen by the student which relates to what is covered in the classroom. The term paper can also be a historical case study of a particular country, but the timeline and the topic of study must be well-defined.

4) Online discussion posts (10%)- There will be online discussions posted each month which pose a question from the readings covered in previous weeks. Students are expected to actively participate in these online posts by posting their answers.

Grading:

Final grades will be determined by weighted numerical averages (not the raw averages reported on Canvas).

Quizzes	20%
Midterm	35%
Final	35%
Online discussion posts	10%

Grade Components

≥ 93.00	A
90.00 – 92.99	A-
87.00 – 89.99	B+
83.00 – 86.99	B
80.00 – 82.99	B-
77.00 – 79.99	C+
73.00 – 76.99	C
70.00 – 72.99	C-
67.00 – 69.99	D+
63.00 – 66.99	D
60.00 – 62.99	D-
≤ 59.99	F

Letter Grade Distribution

Course Schedule:

Date	Week	Topic	Readings
Module 1: Comparative Systems Approach			
Aug 24th	Week 1	Introduction to Economic Systems Analysis	Stuart(1,1) & Rosser(1,1,15-22)
Aug 31st	Week 2	Definitions and Classification of Economic Systems	Stuart (1,2)
Quiz on Week 1 and Week 2: **Due** Tuesday, Sep 8th			
Sep 7th	Week 3	Evaluating Institutions: A Neoclassical Perspective	Stuart(1,3, 54-69)
Sep 14th	Week 4	Introduction to Databases: CPDS and WID	
Quiz on Week 3 and Week 4: **Due** Monday, Sep 21st			
Module 2: Capitalism and Socialism			
Sep 21st	Week 5	The Evolution of Market Capitalism I	Stuart(1,4,86-91) & Rosser(1,2)
Sep 28th	Week 6	Issues with Market Capitalism	Stuart(2,6) & Quantitative Analysis using CPDS
Quiz on Week 5 and Week 6: **Due** Monday, Oct 5th			
Oct 5th	Week 7	The History of Socialist Thought	Rosser(1,3)
Fall Break: October 10–18			
Oct 19th	Week 8	Market Socialism	Stuart(2,7,164-180) & Stuart (2,8)
Midterm of reaction paper: **Due** Tuesday, Oct 27th			
Module 3: Country Studies 1			
Oct 26th	Week 9	USA	Rosser(2,5)
Nov 2nd	Week 10	Japan	Rosser(2,6) & Quantitative Analysis (Data Interpretation): WID
Quiz on Week 9 and Week 10: **Due** Monday, Nov 9th			
Module 4: Country Studies 2			
Nov 9th	Week 11	Russia	Rosser(3,10)
Nov 16th	Week 12	China	Rosser(3,15) & Quantitative Analysis (Data Interpretation): WID
Quiz on Week 11 and Week 12: **Due** Monday, Nov 23rd			
Module 5: Country Studies 3			
Nov 23rd	Week 13	India	Rosser(4,1)
Thanksgiving Break: November 26–29			
Nov 30th	Week 14	Mexico	Rosser(4,18) & Quantitative Analysis: WID

Note:

a. WID = World Inequality Database
b. *Rosser(1,1,10-57)* refers to Section 1, Chapter 1, pages 10-57. If page numbers are not provided, then the entire chapter is to be read.
c. *Stuart(2,1,10-57)* refers to Section 2, Chapter 1, pages 10-57. If page numbers are not provided, then the entire chapter is to be read.

University Policies:

1. **The Americans with Disabilities Act.** The University of Utah seeks to provide equal access to its programs, services, and activities for people with disabilities. If you will need accommodations in this class, reasonable prior notice needs to be given to the Center for Disability & Access, 162 Olpin Union Building, (801) 581-5020. CDA will work with you and the instructor to make arrangements for accommodations. All written information in this course can be made available in an alternative format with prior notification to the Center for Disability & Access.

    - *If in-class attendance is a necessary component of the course for pedagogical reasons (e.g., laboratories, studios, or artistic training), state it explicitly.*

        Use this standard language: "Given the nature of this course, attendance is required and adjustments cannot be granted to allow non-attendance. However, if you need to seek an ADA accommodation to request an exception to this attendance policy due to a disability, please contact the Center for Disability and Access (CDA). CDA will work with us to determine what, if any, ADA accommodations are reasonable and appropriate."

    [Strongly recommended] Basic Needs Student Support Statement. Success at The University of Utah includes learning about and using available resources. The Basic Needs Collective (BNC) is a coordinated resource referral hub. They educate about and connect students to campus and community resources to help them meet their basic needs. As a central location for resource referrals related to food, housing, health insurance, managing finances, legal services, mental health, etc., any student experiencing difficulty with basic needs is encouraged to contact them. Drop into their office located in the Union basement or schedule with them online for an in-person or virtual visit through their webpage: https://basicneeds.utah.edu/.

    [Recommended addendum] In compliance with ADA requirements, some students may need to record course content. Any recordings of course content are for personal use only, should not be shared, and should not be made publicly available. In addition, recordings should be destroyed at the conclusion of the course.

2. **University Safety Statement.** The University of Utah values the safety of all campus community members. To report suspicious activity or to request a courtesy escort, call campus police at 801-585-COPS (801-585-2677). You will receive important emergency alerts and safety messages regarding campus safety via text message. For more information regarding safety and to view available training resources, including helpful videos, visit https://safeu.utah.edu.

3. **Addressing Sexual Misconduct.** Title IX makes it clear that violence and harassment based on sex and gender (which includes sexual orientation and gender identity/expression) is a civil rights offense subject to the same kinds of accountability and support applied to offenses against other protected categories such as race, national origin, color, religion, age, status as a person with a disability, veteran's status or genetic information. If you or someone you know has been harassed or assaulted, you are encouraged to report it to the Title IX Coordinator in the Office of Equal Opportunity and Affirmative Action, 383 South University Street, 801-581-8365, or the Office of the Dean of Students, 270 Union Building, 801-581-7066. For support and confidential consultation, contact the Center for Student Wellness, 426 SSB, 801-581-7776. To report to the police, contact the Department of Public Safety, 801-585-2677 (COPS).

    (a) **[Recommended addendum] Lauren's Promise:** Lauren's Promise is a vow that anyone – faculty, staff, students, parents, and community members – can take to indicate to others that they represent a safe haven for sharing incidents of sexual assault, domestic violence, or stalking. Anyone who makes Lauren's Promise vows to:

i. listen to and believe those individuals who are being threatened or experiencing sexual assault, dating violence or stalking;
ii. represent a safe haven for sharing incidents of sexual assault, domestic violence, or stalking; and
iii. change campus culture that responds poorly to dating violence and stalking. By making Lauren's Promise, individuals are helping to change campus cultures that respond poorly to dating violence and stalking throughout the nation.

4. **Academic Misconduct Statement.** It is expected that students adhere to University of Utah policies regarding academic honesty, including but not limited to refraining from cheating, plagiarizing, misrepresenting one's work, and/or inappropriately collaborating. This includes the use of generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools without citation, documentation, or authorization. Students are expected to adhere to the prescribed professional and ethical standards of the profession/discipline for which they are preparing. Any student who engages in academic dishonesty or who violates the professional and ethical standards for their profession/discipline may be subject to academic sanctions as per the University of Utah's Student Code: https://regulations.utah.edu/academics/6-410.php.

*[The following statements are **encouraged** by the University for every syllabi. It is up to the instructors to determine if it is appropriate for their class.]*

5. **[recommended]** *Diversity Statement.* I stand in support of compassion, dignity, value-of-life, equity, inclusion and justice for all individuals regardless of color, race/ethnicity, sexual orientation, religion, language, socioeconomic status, ability, gender, gender identity or expression, immigration status, or any type of marginalization. I stand in support of making our society more inclusive, just, and equitable for all individuals. I stand against individual and systemic racism in all its various forms.

6. **[recommended]** *Undocumented Student Support Statement.* Immigration is a complex phenomenon with broad impact—those who are directly affected by it, as well as those who are indirectly affected by their relationships with family members, friends, and loved ones. If your immigration status presents obstacles to engaging in specific activities or fulfilling specific course criteria, confidential arrangements may be requested from the Dream Center. Arrangements with the Dream Center will not jeopardize your student status, your financial aid, or any other part of your residence. The Dream Center offers a wide range of resources to support undocumented students (with and without DACA) as well as students from mixed-status families. To learn more, please contact the Dream Center at 801.213.3697 or visit https://dream.utah.edu.

7. **[recommended]** *Drop/Withdrawal Policies.* Students may drop a course within the first two weeks of a given semester without any penalties. Students may officially withdraw (W) from a class or all classes after the drop deadline through the midpoint of a course. A "W" grade is recorded on the transcript and appropriate tuition/fees are assessed. The grade "W" is not used in calculating the student's GPA. For deadlines to withdraw from full-term, first, and second session classes, see the U's Academic Calendar.

8. **[recommended]** *Other important information to consider including:*

   (a) *Student Code:* http://regulations.utah.edu/academics/6-400.php
   (b) *Accommodation Policy (see Section Q):* http://regulations.utah.edu/academics/6-100.php

9. **[Recommended] Student Mental Health Resources**

- *If you need help dealing with burnout, anxiety, depression, isolation, and loneliness, or other mental health issues please, reach out. Here are some campus mental health resources, including free counseling, trainings and other support.*
- *Consider participating in a Mental Health First Aid or other wellness-themed training provided by our Center for Student Wellness and sharing these opportunities with your peers, teaching assistants and department colleagues.*

10. **[Recommended] Diverse Supports for Students.** Your success at the University of Utah is important to all of us here! If you feel like you need extra support in academics, overcoming personal difficulties, or finding community, the U is here for you.

    Student Support Services (TRIO)

    TRIO federal programs are targeted to serve and assist low-income individuals, first-generation college students, and individuals with disabilities.

    Student Support Services (SSS) is a TRIO program for current or incoming undergraduate university students who are seeking their bachelor's degree and need academic assistance and other services to be successful at the University of Utah.

    For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

    Student Support Services (TRIO)
    801-581-7188
    trio.utah.edu
    Room 2075
    1901 E. S. Campus Dr.
    Salt Lake City, UT 84112

    American Indian Students

    The AIRC works to increase American Indian student visibility and success on campus by advocating for and providing student-centered programs and tools to enhance academic success, cultural events to promote personal well-being, and a supportive "home-away-from-home" space for students to grow and develop leadership skills.

    For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

    American Indian Resource Center
    801-581-7019
    https://diversity.utah.edu/centers/airc
    Fort Douglas Building 622
    1925 De Trobriand St.
    Salt Lake City, UT 84113

    Black Students

    Using a pan-African lens, the Black Cultural Center seeks to counteract persistent campus-wide and global anti-blackness. The Black Cultural Center works to holistically enrich, educate, and advocate for students, faculty, and staff through Black-centered programming, culturally affirming educational initiatives, and retention strategies.

    For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Black Cultural Center
801-213-1441
https://diversity.utah.edu/centers/bcc
Fort Douglas Building 603
95 Fort Douglas Blvd.
Salt Lake City, UT 84113

Students with Children

Our mission is to support and coordinate information, program development, and services that enhance family resources as well as the availability, affordability, and quality of childcare for University students, faculty, and staff.

For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Center for Childcare & Family Resources
801-585-5897
https://childcare.utah.edu
408 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Students with Disabilities

The Center for Disability & Access is dedicated to serving students with disabilities by providing the opportunity for success and equal access at the University of Utah. They also strive to create an inclusive, safe, and respectful environment.

For more information about what support they provide and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Center for Disability & Access
801-581-5020
https://disability.utah.edu
162 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Students across Intersectional Identities and Experiences

The Center for Equity & Student Belonging (CESB) creates community and advocates for academic success and belonging for students across intersectional identities and experiences among our African, African American, Black, Native, Indigenous, American Indian, Asian, Asian American, Latinx, Chicanx, Pacific Islander, Multiracial, LGBTQ+, Neurodiverse, and Disabled students of color.

For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Center for Equity and Student Belonging (CESB)
801-581-8151
https://diversity.utah.edu/centers/cesa
235 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.

Salt Lake City, UT 84112

English as a Second/Additional Language (ESL) Students

If you are an English language learner, there are several resources on campus available to help you develop your English writing and language skills. Feel free to contact:

Writing Center
801-587-9122
http://writingcenter.utah.edu
2701 Marriott Library
295 S 1500 E
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

English Language Institute
801-581-4600
http://continue.utah.edu/eli
540 Arapeen Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84108

Undocumented Students

Immigration is a complex phenomenon with broad impact—those who are directly affected by it, as well as those who are indirectly affected by their relationships with family members, friends, and loved ones. If your immigration status presents obstacles to engaging in specific activities or fulfilling specific course criteria, confidential arrangements may be requested from the Dream Center.

Arrangements with the Dream Center will not jeopardize your student status, your financial aid, or any other part of your residence. The Dream Center offers a wide range of resources to support undocumented students (with and without DACA) as well as students from mixed-status families.

For more information about what support they provide and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Dream Center
801-581-3470
http://dream.utah.edu
1120 Annex (Wing B)
1901 E. S. Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

LGBTQ+ Students

The LGBTQ+ Resource Center acts in accountability with the campus community by identifying the needs of people with a queer range of [a]gender and [a]sexual experiences and responding with university-wide services.

For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

LGBTQ+ Resource Center
801-587-7973
http://lgbt.utah.edu
409 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.

Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Veterans & Military Students

The mission of the Veterans Support Center is to improve and enhance the individual and academic success of veterans, service members, and their family members who attend the university; to help them receive the benefits they earned; and to serve as a liaison between the student veteran community and the university.

For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Veterans Support Center
801-587-7722
http://veteranscenter.utah.edu
418 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Women

The Women's Resource Center (WRC) at the University of Utah serves as the central resource for educational and support services for women. Honoring the complexities of women's identities, the WRC facilitates choices and changes through programs, counseling, and training grounded in a commitment to advance social justice and equality.

For more information about what support they provide, a list of ongoing events, and links to other resources, view their website or contact:

Women's Resource Center
801-581-8030
https://womenscenter.utah.edu
411 Union Building
200 S. Central Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Food Pantry

The University of Utah food pantry provides non-perishable, nourishing food for our students, their families, faculty, and staff.

For more information about what support they provide and links to other resources, view their website:

Feed U Pantry
feedufoodpantry@gmail.com
https://union.utah.edu/resources-spaces/feed-u-pantry/hours-about-us/
Union Building (Pantry is located on the basement level)
200 S. Central Campus Dr.
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Tutoring

The Learning Center offers free services to currently-enrolled University of Utah students.

For more information about what support they provide and links to other resources, view their website.

Learning Center
801-581-5153
https://learningcenter.utah.edu
1705 J. Willard Marriott Library
295 S. 1500 E
Salt Lake City, UT 84112

Other Student Groups at the U

To learn more about some of the other resource groups available at the U, check out:

https://getinvolved.utah.edu/
https://studentsuccess.utah.edu/resources/student-support/